Write Down How Mom's Week Really Works, While There Is Time

Four prompts to capture an ordinary week, count the help already in place, compare what relatives see, and leave with a snapshot the family can return to.

Where you are

Mom is doing fine, mostly. Nothing has happened. But you've noticed the small things, a sister who drives her to appointments, a neighbor who brings in the mail, and you suspect the family would not tell the same story if asked.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have one shared picture of her week and the help around her, written while everyone is calm, and the family knows where it is kept.

A one-page family snapshot with four headings: Her Ordinary Week, Help Already in Place, Where Our Pictures Differ, and Things to Gather While There Is Time.

Before you start

- A conversation with Mom about what her week looks like, or a plan to have one.
- A rough idea of who helps her and with what, including the small things.
- A few lines from one or two relatives on how they see things. A short text reply counts. You don't need all three to begin.

PROMPT 1

Let her describe an ordinary week

WHY THIS MATTERS

The best source on Mom's week is Mom. Asking her to describe it, rather than announcing that the family is 'getting organized,' keeps her in charge of her own story.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Notes from a relaxed conversation with her about what a normal week looks like.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I asked my mother to walk me through an ordinary week, and here is what she told me, plus a few things I noticed:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Lay this out as a simple week: MORNINGS, DAYTIME, EVENINGS, and OVERNIGHT, with weekdays and weekends separate if she described them differently. For each part of the day, note what she does on her own, what someone helps with, and what she didn't mention at all. Keep her wording where I quoted her. This is a description, not an evaluation, so don't comment on whether anything is a concern.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A week that sounds like her, with the quiet hours visible.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read it back to her and let her correct it.

PROMPT 2

Count the help that is already there

WHY THIS MATTERS

Rides, bill paying, a weekly phone call, someone who changes the smoke detector battery. None of it feels like caregiving, and all of it is. Written down, it shows how much is already being done and by whom.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A list of everyone who does something for Mom, however small.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everyone who helps my mother in some way, and what I know about it:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Make a table with these columns: WHO, WHAT THEY DO, HOW OFTEN, ROUGHLY HOW MUCH TIME, and WHETHER ANYONE ELSE KNOWS HOW TO DO IT. Include the small things I may have listed as an afterthought. Then write two short lists: tasks that depend on a single person, and tasks I mentioned but couldn't say who does them. Add a rough total of hours per week if there is enough to estimate.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The total hours, and the tasks only one person knows how to do.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Check with each person on the list that you've described their part fairly. Most will add something.

PROMPT 3

Compare what each relative sees

WHY THIS MATTERS

Everyone in the family has a slightly different mother. The sibling who visits on Sundays and the one who calls on Wednesday nights are seeing different hours of the same week. The differences are useful, not a problem.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

A few lines from two or three relatives about how they think she is doing and what they help with.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I asked some of my family to describe, in a few lines each, how our mother is doing and what they do for her. Here is what they wrote:
>
> [PASTE EACH PERSON'S REPLY, LABELED WITH THEIR NAME OR INITIAL]
>
> Show me three things: WHERE WE AGREE, WHERE WE DESCRIBE THINGS DIFFERENTLY, and WHAT ONLY ONE PERSON MENTIONED. Quote each person's words rather than paraphrasing. Don't decide whose version is correct, and don't suggest what the differences mean. Finish with three questions the family could settle just by talking to each other.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The things only one person noticed. Those are usually the ones worth a phone call.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Share the three questions with the family and let them answer in their own time.

PROMPT 4

Make the snapshot and decide when to look again

WHY THIS MATTERS

A snapshot is only useful if someone can find it and knows when to update it. The last job is to put everything on one page and name the kinds of changes that would mean it's time to look again.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of all three prompts above.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my family has put together about our mother's current situation:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF THE THREE PROMPTS ABOVE]
>
> Write a one-page snapshot with four headings: HER ORDINARY WEEK, HELP ALREADY IN PLACE, WHERE OUR PICTURES DIFFER, and THINGS TO GATHER WHILE THERE IS TIME. Under the last heading, list the practical information the family hasn't collected yet, such as who her doctors are, what paperwork exists, or how she gets to appointments, drawn only from gaps in what I pasted. End with a short line that begins “We will look at this again if...” and list three or four everyday changes that would make it worth updating.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page the family could read in five minutes and recognize as true.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Decide where the page will live, tell everyone, and bring it to the next step below.

Keep going while it's still quiet.

A snapshot written in calm times is the best possible starting point. The care interview takes it further, asking about Mom's situation area by area and giving the family one Family Care Profile to keep current as things change.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›